

This, that, and it

Teaching guide

Refer clearly to objects and ideas in context.

Understand the distinction

This and that can point to objects or refer to ideas. This often presents something as near or currently in focus; that can refer back or suggest greater distance. The distance may be physical, conversational, or emotional.

Either speaker can use this or that. There is no rule that this must refer to your own idea and that to someone else's. It often continues a reference to an identified thing or situation.

Name the idea again when a pronoun would be unclear.

Compare the patterns

IN FOCUS

This is my main concern: the cost.

This introduces the idea in focus.

REFER BACK

I missed the train. That made me late.

The same speaker refers back to their own statement.

CONTINUE

I bought a bag. It is very light.

It continues the reference to the bag.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Can the same speaker say I lost my key. That was frustrating?

2. What does it refer to in I found a notebook. It was empty?

3. Improve the unclear It was a problem after mentioning two possible problems.

Use it in your own life

Write two linked sentences with an unambiguous reference.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. Yes. That can refer back to the speaker's own event.

Pronoun choice is not determined by who first mentioned the idea.

2. The notebook.

It continues an identified reference.

3. Name the problem, for example: The missing address was a problem.

A noun phrase removes the ambiguous reference.

One possible response

The bus was canceled. That meant I had to walk home.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-28.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Write two linked sentences with an unambiguous reference.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.